

Muskegon MI, 9/21/2026

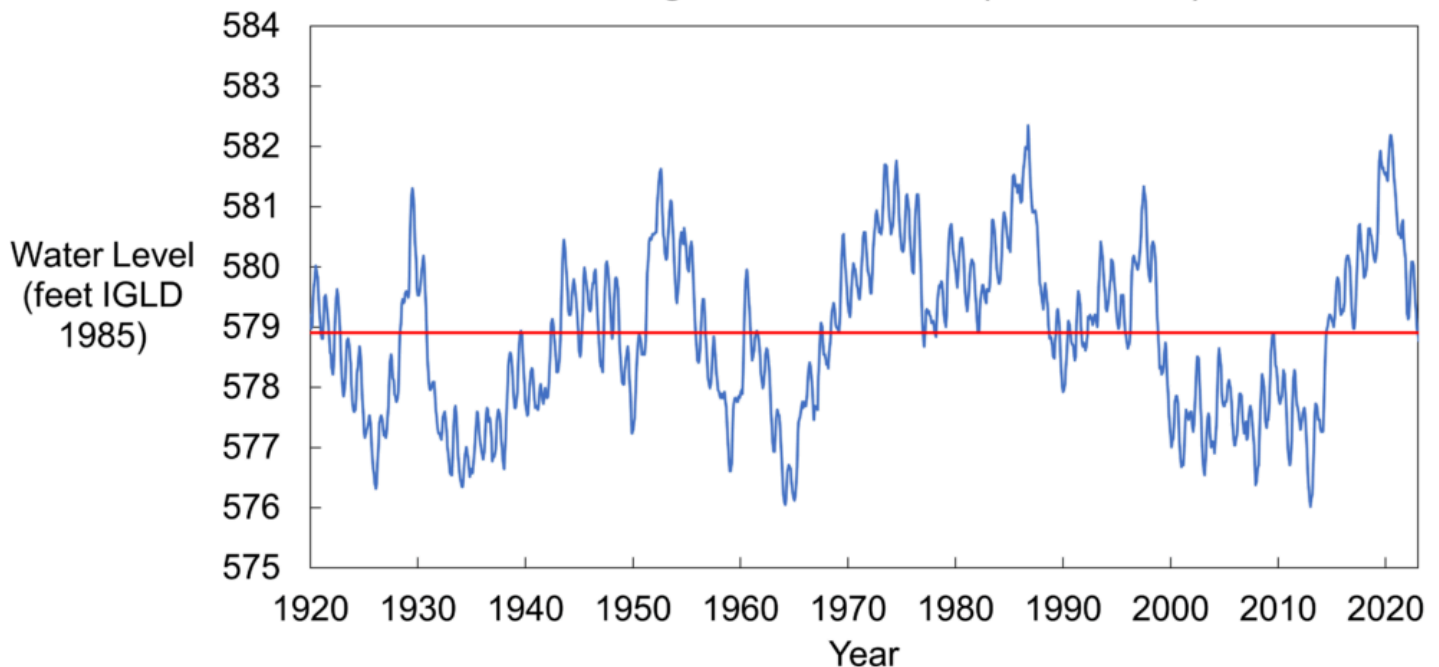
The Return of the Beach

For the last several years, the beach of the great Lake Michigan has been consistantly shrinking. But now it finally seems like things might be turning around, the beach is finally coming back. This is of course a continuous cycle and has happened just like this for a long time. As this is happening we will take a look at how and why this happens, and talk to some locals (these locals may or may probabaly not be real people). So lets explore why in the same decade you may see the lake on the news for eating homes, and a large beach perfect to enjoy a summer day.

The Science

It all begins with how much water is going into the lake over a period of time. Obviously, these changes don't happen quickly or frequently, rather instead they happen slowly over long periods of time. This all must be understood with the context that Lake Michigan flows out into the Atlantic Ocean and does not hold water permanently. In some seasons there is greater percipitation and humidity, and this can raise the water level over time. Meanwhile, on the other hand, in a long dry season with little rain and low humidity, the water level will be lower. The sheer size of the Great Lakes means that a significant amount of water can be added over night by a single large storm, but even when what misses the lake ends up there eventually. Every year this can be observed every spring, when the snow melts the water levels shoot up even several feet. In recent year leading up to 2020 this cycle of adding water to the lake too fast was almost never ending. The water level rose several feet and ate up most of the beach and even some lakeside homes. When it starts to get cold, however, significant amounts of water are evaporated and the water level decends. At the end of the 90s there is a good example of this decline, there was a time of irregular warmth, and with it the lake quickly retreated down the shore. Another time in 2013, not long before the great accent that lasted until 2020, the lake hit a extreme low, so low that people began to be signifcantly concerned.

Lake Michigan Water Level (1920-2024)



Above is an image from *Wisconsin Coastal Resilience* depicting recorded water levels over the last 100 years

The People's Thoughts

We examined this phenomonon for ourselves, and we talked to a few locals about it. A man by the name of Dave explained “I remember when I was a kid the water was really low, we had a boat in a marina and we couldn't use it for a long time because the water was so low that almost anywhere in the marina you could wade in it up to your knees or lower.” Another man going by the name of Bill told us, “Back in the day I owned a house on a dune, bought it for a good bit of money too, too much my wife said. And I suppose it was too much considering it only lasted for *two years*. That's right, it hung maybe fifteen feet over the edge of the dune on suport beams that went down to the beach. Now I didn't really give it too much thought, but that second April the water was so high it took them right out. Now I suppose that was to blame in part on cheap constuction, but I don't think they would have counted on that much water for that long anyway. But what do you know, it happened again recently, and now it' goin' back down agian.” On this note it is good to add that it is **important** to examine the structuaral integrity of a building in relation to its geographic location.

Citations

Callahan, E. (2026, September 18). How Great Lakes Water Levels Rise And Fall So Dramatically. WorldAtlas. <https://www.worldatlas.com/lakes/how-great-lakes-water-levels-rise-and-fall-so-dramatically.html>